to some treasonous outsider group – Jews, communists, liberals – instead of to the people.

The Nazi case is of course extreme, and it is grossly unfair to accuse all populists of being crypto-Nazis with genocidal inclinations. However, many populist parties and politicians deny that 'the people' might contain a diversity of opinions and interest groups. They insist that the real people has only one will and that they alone represent this will. In contrast, their political rivals – even when the latter enjoy substantial popular support – are depicted as 'alien elites'. Thus, Hugo Chávez ran for the presidency in Venezuela with the slogan 'Chávez is the people!'[10] President Erdoğan of Turkey once railed against his domestic critics, saying, 'We are the people. Who are you?' – as if his critics weren't Turks, too.[11]

How can you tell, then, whether someone is part of the people or not? Easy. If they support the leader, they are part of the people. This, according to the German political philosopher Jan-Werner Müller, is the defining feature of populism. What turns someone into a populist is claiming that they alone represent the people and that anyone who disagrees with them – whether state bureaucrats, minority groups or even the majority of voters – either suffers from false consciousness or isn't really part of the people.[12]

This is why populism poses a deadly threat to democracy. While democracy agrees that the people is the only legitimate source of power, democracy is based on the understanding that the people is never a unitary entity and therefore cannot possess a single will. Every people – whether Germans, Venezuelans or Turks – is composed of many different groups, with a plurality of opinions, wills and representatives. No group, including the majority group, is entitled to exclude other groups from membership in the people. This is what makes democracy a conversation. Holding a conversation presupposes the existence of several legitimate voices. If, however, the people has only one legitimate voice, there can be no conversation. Rather, the single voice dictates everything. Populism may therefore claim adherence to the democratic principle of 'people's power', but it effectively empties democracy of meaning and seeks to establish a dictatorship.

Populism undermines democracy in another, more subtle but equally dangerous way. Having claimed that they alone represent the people, populists argue that the people is not just the sole legitimate source of political authority but the sole legitimate source of *all* authority. Any